



Unadkat, however, points out that starting red-ball cricket as early as October could be tough for fast bowlers.

"It's a good move by the BCCI to split the season, as it gives more game time to teams whose matches are often disrupted by extreme weather.

"But now, with the heat in many parts of the country, I don't think the new ball will move much in the first couple of days, as it would in the winter," Unadkat says.

"If you're playing in Rajkot or Chennai, you'll see a lot of reverse swing. It's always a challenge to play five red-ball games in October when it's still very hot, but we need to adapt to the conditions and play accordingly," he adds.

In recent years, excelling in the IPL has often fast-tracked a player's inclusion in the Indian team, but there are always exceptions.

A notable example is Yashasvi Jaiswal. While his stellar performances for Rajasthan Royals in IPL 2023 (625 runs at a strike rate of 163.61) grabbed headlines, his dominant red-ball form also helped pave the way for his Test debut.

Around the time of his Test selection, Jaiswal boasted a remarkable First-Class average in the 80s. His standout performance came in the Irani Cup in March last year, where he hammered scores of 213 and 144.

The inclusion of players like Sarfaraz Khan, Rajat Patidar and Dhruv Jurel in the Indian Test team, after strong performances in the Ranji Trophy, has also given hope to others.



List of Ranji Trophy winners since 2014

2014-15: Karnataka
2015-16: Mumbai
2016-17: Gujarat
2017-18: Vidarbha
2018-19: Vidarbha
2019-20: Saurashtra
2021-22: Madhya Pradesh
2022-23: Saurashtra
2023-24: Mumbai

"There's no substitute for hard work," Pandit says as he prepares for another exciting season with Madhya Pradesh.

Meanwhile, expectations will be high from Mumbai after the Irani Cup win. But Ajinkya Rahane's side will need to stay grounded and address each challenge as it comes. With India set to play New Zealand in a three-match Test series, it's unlikely that Mumbai's run-machine Sarfaraz will be available for much of the Ranji Trophy.

This, however, opens the door for others to step up.

Players like Pradosh Ranjan Paul, Manav Suthar, Riyan Parag, and Abhimanyu Easwaran will be eager to make their mark, while **seasoned veterans such as Wriddhiman Saha, Cheteshwar Pujara, and Rahane might see this as an opportunity to showcase their class and perhaps bow out on a high note.**

With plenty of action ahead, another thrilling season of Ranji Trophy cricket awaits.

« **It's not that traditionally top teams are struggling, but rather that other teams have upped their game. With a large talent pool and ample opportunities, players from smaller centres are now rubbing shoulders with big names, boosting their confidence. They have nothing to lose, so they seize every chance that comes their way** – P.V. Shashikanth, head coach, Tripura

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